

SOP: Diarrhea in Dogs - Treatment Protocol

Department: Animal Services

Purpose:

To provide a consistent protocol for evaluating and treating dogs presenting with diarrhea in the shelter to ensure appropriate medical care, infection control, and timely resolution of symptoms.

Scope:

This SOP applies to all dogs presenting with diarrhea within the shelter setting.

Procedure

1. Initial Assessment

- Observe and document the dog's overall condition, including hydration status, appetite, energy level, and stool characteristics (consistency, frequency, presence of blood, mucus, or parasites).
- If diarrhea is **bloody**, a **parvovirus antigen test** must be performed immediately, regardless of age, before any other treatment or testing is initiated.

2. Diagnostic Testing

- Perform a **fecal flotation** (or equivalent fecal exam) on all dogs with diarrhea.
- Record results in the medical record.

3. Treatment Protocol

- **If fecal is positive:**
 - Initiate treatment based on the identified parasite or pathogen as directed by the veterinarian.
- **If fecal is negative:**

- **Fenbendazole (Panacur):** Administer once daily for 3 days (dose per weight chart).
- **Pro-Pectalin:** 1 chewable tablet per 20 lbs body weight, given **twice daily for 2 days**.
- **FortiFlora:** 1 packet mixed with food once daily until diarrhea resolves and continued for **1 week afterward**.
- **Important:** Pro-Pectalin and FortiFlora should not be administered at the same time as antibiotics. Give at least **1-2 hours apart**.
- Special diets (e.g., gastrointestinal-support diets) may be started at the veterinarian's discretion.
- **If diarrhea continues despite above treatment:**
 - **Metronidazole:** 10–15 mg/kg, given **twice daily for 5–7 days**.
- **If diarrhea persists after metronidazole:**
 - Repeat a **fecal flotation** prior to additional testing.
 - If still negative and diarrhea persists, submit a **fecal PCR panel**.

4. Reevaluation and Monitoring

- Monitor and document stool consistency daily.
 - Reassess hydration, weight, and overall condition throughout treatment.
 - Escalate to veterinarian if diarrhea worsens, fails to improve, or if systemic illness develops.
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Documentation

- Record all test results, treatments, diet changes, and progress notes in the medical record.
- Ensure medication dosages and durations are clearly documented and administered as prescribed.

Notes

- Supportive care (fluids, anti-nausea medications, etc.) may be provided at the veterinarian's discretion.
- Dogs with confirmed or suspected contagious causes must follow the **appropriate SOP for that specific pathogen** in addition to this protocol.